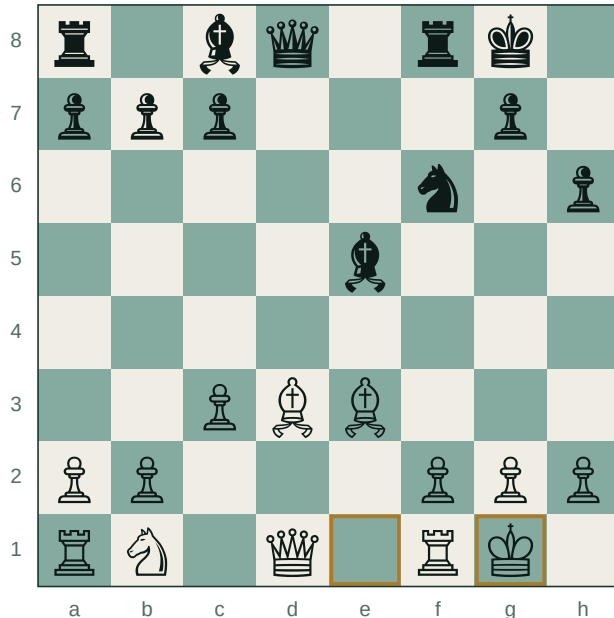


Clearance tactics: Black, move 12

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 12.O-O. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

12...Bxh2+ 13. Kxh2 Ng4+ 14. Kg1 Qh4

12...Bxh2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on h2. Recorded reply: **13.Kxh2**.

13...Ng4+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. From g4 it attacks king on h2 and bishop on e3. Recorded reply: **14.Kg1**.

14...Qh4 The queen moves from d8 to h4.

At the end, nominal material is White 33 / Black 30 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -2: the balance goes from -1 to -3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.